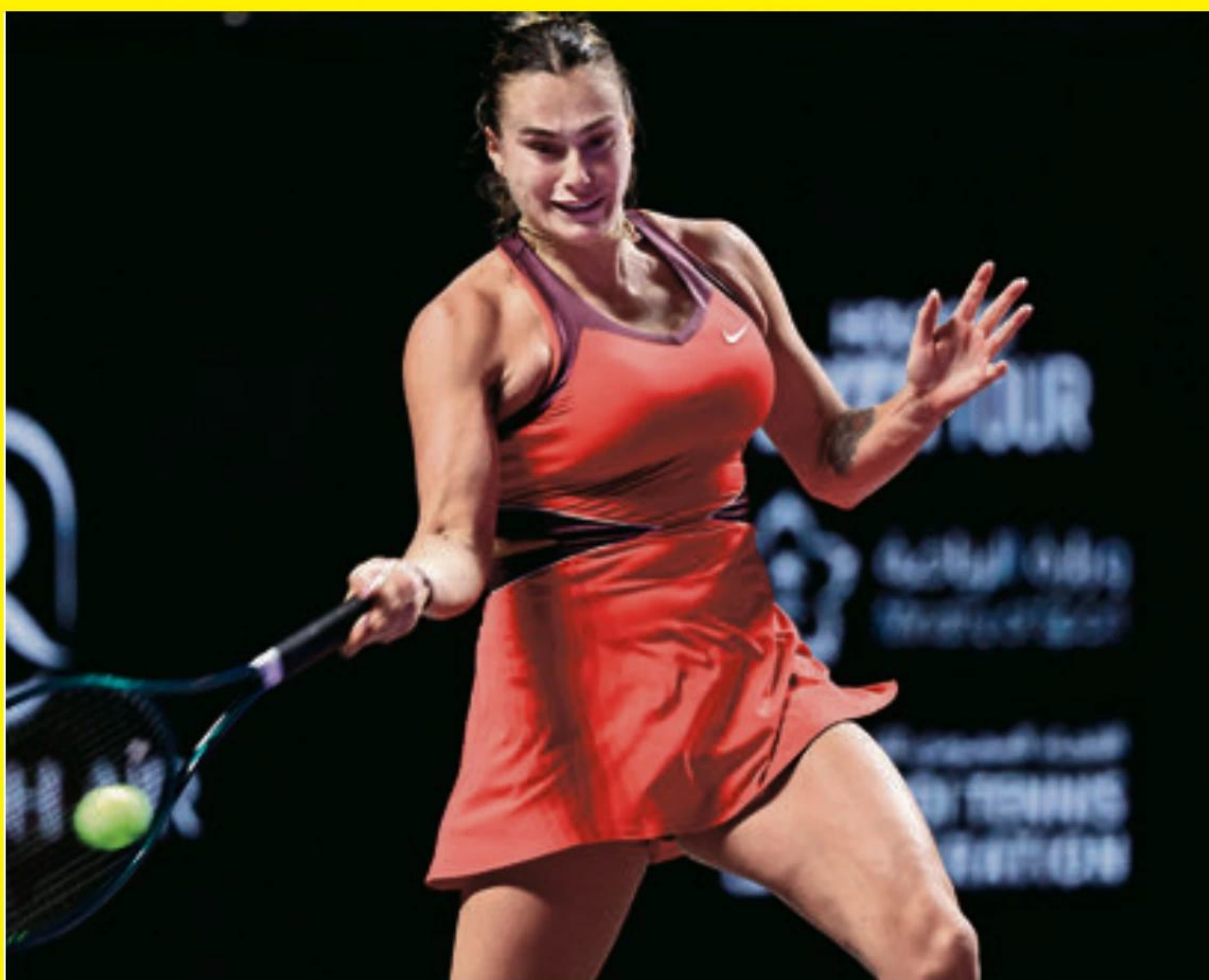




Test of focus: For Sabalenka, the final was a mental battle as much as a physical one. AFP

appreciative spectators gave Alcaraz a long, loud ovation.

Both these young giants will no doubt come up with new tactics and tricks during the short off-season to prepare for the Australian circuit in January. The sporting world can hardly wait for the renewal of the most exciting, spectacular rivalry in tennis.

RESURGENT RYBAKINA OUTSLUGS SABALENKA FOR WTA FINALS TITLE

If you like surprise champions and contrasting personalities, this WTA Finals showdown was for you. It featured fiery Aryna Sabalenka, who sports a tiger tattoo on her forearm, versus icy Elena Rybakina, who wears no emotions on her countenance, save for an occasional enigmatic Mona Lisa smile.

Neither had ever won the prestigious, season-ending title in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia. Both were vying for the \$5.235 million prize, the most lucrative payday in women's sporting history. Although Sabalenka ranked No. 1 throughout the year and would keep the top spot, win or

lose, she wanted to finish with a flourish after losing heartbreaking three-setters in the Australian and French finals and Wimbledon semifinals. When Rybakina won the 2022 Wimbledon and made the 2023 Australian final, she looked like a sure-fire contender for Grand Slam titles for the rest of the decade. Instead, illnesses, injuries, and a coaching controversy reversed her momentum.

Rybakina failed to reach another Slam final, and this year did not even reach a Major quarterfinal. But these setbacks left the Russian-born Kazakhstani, who ranked a career-high No. 3 in January 2024, with a burning desire to regain her status as an elite player.

"We've been waiting for Elena to play her best tennis, seeing her healthy, happy, and calm on the court," said *Tennis Channel* analyst Lindsay Davenport after Rybakina, now 26 and in what should be the prime of her career, whipped four of the world's top five players to capture the WTA Finals.

Her career resurgence began at Cincinnati, where Rybakina defeated Sabalenka and Madison Keys, the Australian Open champion. She picked up steam when she won the Ningbo Open in China and made the Tokyo semis to become the last

player to qualify for the WTA Finals.

A fortune reversal of this magnitude seemed improbable back in January. Although Rybakina consistently denied that Stefano Vukov, her coach, had psychologically abused her, she fired him anyway just before the 2024 US Open. She then hired Goran Ivanisevic, whose tenure lasted a month, and after that David Sanguinetti for another brief stint.

In February 2025, the WTA Tour suspended Vukov for one year for violating its code of conduct. In a confidential summary of the investigation obtained by *The Athletic*, WTA CEO Portia Archer found Vukov had been "engaging in abuse of authority and abusive conduct towards the WTA player." Vukov appealed the suspension in May, and it was lifted in August.

Vukov often shouted advice to Rybakina during her five victories at the WTA Finals. While that might seem a lot for any player to process, it apparently helped, particularly in Rybakina's comeback wins — over six-time Major titlist Iga Swiatek 3-6, 6-1, 6-0 and Jessica Pegula 4-6, 6-4, 6-3.

The Rybakina-Pegula semifinal matched the Tour's best server against one of the best returners. A 6-footer with impeccable serving technique, Rybakina led the Tour in aces — finishing with 516 — and a whopping 54 per cent of her first serves went unreturned going into the semifinals.

The late-blooming Pegula, who won three titles this year on three different surfaces, became the oldest semifinalist at 31 since 37-year-old Venus Williams in 2017. The faster conditions, particularly the 2,000-foot altitude and lighter regular-duty balls, favoured Rybakina.

Pegula, the runner-up at the 2023 WTA Finals, broke Rybakina's serve twice in the opening set to take it 6-4, thanks mostly to the Kazakh's 24 unforced errors, including 15 from her flat forehand.

Counterintuitively, in the second set, she hit forehands with much less net clearance — 23" compared to 37" in the first set — less spin and more